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IN BRIEF

DMDK calls for forming panel to fix MSP for farmers

DMDK general secretary Premalatha Vijayakant on Friday urged the Tamil Nadu government to constitute a committee to recommend minimum support price (MSP) for agricultural produce, alleging that farmers were being affected by low prices and power supply issues. In a statement, Ms. Premalatha said farmers in Cuddalore, Virudhunagar, and other districts were struggling as agricultural produce was not fetching remunerative prices despite their strenuous and hard work. She also alleged that frequent power cuts had disrupted agricultural activities and added to farmers' difficulties.

Fisheries varsity extends UG admission deadline to June 23

The last date for submission of online applications of the undergraduate (UG) admissions in Tamil Nadu Dr. J. Jayalalithaa Fisheries University, Nagapattinam, for the academic year 2026-27 has been extended to June 23. An official release said the deadline, originally set for June 16, had been extended in view of requests received from prospective applicants and to facilitate wider participation. The university will provide an "application correction window" from June 24 to 26. Applicants can visit the UG Admission Help Desk (10 a.m. to 5 p.m. on working days) or contact 8122410031 for more information.

Vijay announces ₹134-crore Kuruvai Special Package for farmers in delta, other regions

A total of ₹75 crore has been allocated for delta areas, while ₹57.33 crore has been allocated for other districts. Uninterrupted three-phase power supply will be provided for 18 hours a day. Further, 10,714 tonnes of paddy seeds and 4.02 lakh tonnes of fertilizers have been stocked for cultivation

The Hindu correspondent
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday announced a ₹134.43-crore Kuruvai Special Package for paddy cultivation in the Cauvery delta districts and other areas of the State.

According to an official release, paddy is cultivated on 52.72 lakh acres across the State. In the Cauvery delta region, comprising Thanjavur, Tiruvarur, Nagapattinam, and Mayiladuthurai districts, and certain parts of Cuddalore, Tirunchi, and Ariyalur districts, paddy is cultivated annually on 20.05 lakh acres, of which an average of 5.5 lakh acres is cultivated during the Kuruvai season. In other districts, paddy cultivation is undertaken annually on 32.07 lakh acres, of which an average of 5.48 lakh acres is cultivated during the Kuruvai season. Usually, the Mettur dam is opened on the customary date of June 12 every year to facilitate Samba/Thaladi cultivation in the delta districts.

However, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast that rainfall during the south-west monsoon may be below normal due to the El Niño effect. As the south-west monsoon has been delayed, inflow into the Mettur dam has remained low. At present, the water level in the dam stands at only 79.58 feet (with a storage of 41.52 tmcft), and there is no possibility of opening the dam on June 12, the release said.

As a result, there is little possibility of cultivating paddy on the initial 5 lakh acres in the Cauvery delta districts. However, since cultivation can still be carried out on up to 3.35 lakh acres through filter points in shallow areas, and in farmers in other districts are facing irregular rainfall conditions, Mr. Vijay has announced the implementation of the Special Kuruvai Special Package for 2026 to protect farmers' livelihoods and ensure adequate paddy cultivation, the release said.

A total of ₹75 crore has been allocated for delta areas, while ₹57.33 crore has been allocated for other districts. Through this package, mechanisation will be encouraged and water management improved. The scheme will also help raise farmers' income and strengthen the State's food security, the release said.

Further, through the Agricultural Engineering Department, desilting works, covering 2,325 km of C and D channels in the delta districts have been completed at a cost of ₹50 crore. In addition, desilting works covering 4,591 km of A and B channels are being carried out by the Water Resources Department at a cost of ₹100 crore, of which 97% has been completed so far, the release said. Further, 10,714 tonnes of paddy seeds and 4.02 lakh tonnes of fertilisers have been stocked for Kuruvai cultivation. In addition, uninterrupted three-phase power supply will be provided for 18 hours a day, it added.

While welcoming the Chief Minister's announcement, Dwarimukhi Virudhagiri, secretary, Tamil Nadu Cauvery Farmers Protection Association, said a target of area of cultivation should be fixed. "The benefits of the package should not be denied to farmers who take up cultivation by deploying farm labourers. Those taking cultivation purposes to pump water from deep borewells, as they have do not have power connections on their farms, should be provided diesel at full subsidy. Besides, the government should come out with an alternative plan for canal-irrigated farmers who are unable to take up cultivation," he added.

'A huge shock'

In a social media post, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Friday said the State government's move not to open the Mettur dam for irrigation had caused a "huge shock" to farmers in the Cauvery delta. He said farmers had been "forced" to resort to agitations as they had been given only a "pittance" in the form of crop loan waiver. Apart from not opening the dam, the government had come out with the special package, which was "yet another disappointing announcement."

He contended that the duration of power supply to farmers, which was for 24 hours when the AIADMK was in power, had been reduced to 18 hours under the present regime. In view of "unscheduled load shedding," those having farm pumpset connections on their farms should be provided diesel at full subsidy, he added.

Mr. Palaniswami also urged the Tamil Nadu government to declare the Cauvery delta districts drought-affected and provide relief to farmers, citing the non-release of water from the Mettur dam this year. In a statement, he said timely water intervention could lead to production losses of around ₹2,000 crore and affect lakhs of agricultural labourers.

He called for drought relief, consultations on alternative short-duration crops, a Kuruvai package with an input subsidy of ₹5,000 per acre, and uninterrupted three-phase power supply for farmers.

Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) leader G.K. Vasan said farmers were concerned because water had not been released from the Mettur dam.

He urged the Tamil Nadu government to take steps to secure the release of Cauvery water from Karnataka. In a statement, he also urged the State government to ensure uninterrupted three-phase power supply to farmers. Mr. Vasan contended that when farmers were forced to rely on groundwater for irrigation, it affected the water table and led to high electricity consumption.

Farmers, environmentalists oppose proposal for hydrocarbon wells off Parangipettai coast

S. Prasad
CUDDALORE

Farmers and environmental groups have voiced strong opposition to the proposal of Hindustan Oil Exploration Company Limited (HOEC) to drill four hydrocarbon wells in and around the Parangipettai coast in Cuddalore district. The proposed wells fall within the Coastal Regulatory Zone-IVA.

The location of the proposed wells, which is three to 4 km from the mangrove zone in Vadaikuttai at Pichavaram Reserve Forest and mangroves near Parangipettai, has come under criticism with various stakeholders, including fishermen and farmers in the Cauvery Delta region. Environmentalists warn the mangroves, which are home to several species of fish and fauna, will be under threat if the project is implemented.

The Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas issued a notice inviting bids under the Open Acreage Licensing Policy. HOEC, which had submitted an Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) report, said the proposed project was to offset the decline in production without increasing approved production levels in PY-1 field, Cauvery Basin. The estimated cost of the project is ₹628 crore. The application was submitted on June 1 and is currently under examination of the Tamil Nadu Coastal Zone Management Authority. The four development wells have been proposed off the Parangipettai coast. Each well will go as deep as 3,000 metres, according to the EIA, with seismic surveys and heavy drilling equipment to precede exploration.

Threat to environment

According to G. Sundarrajan of Poovulagin Nanbargal, "Drilling hydrocarbon wells in coastal areas has severe environmental impacts and poses major risks to marine life. With rising sea temperatures and disruption of marine ecosystem, projects such as this will destroy coastal natural resources and seriously affect the livelihood of fishermen and can have significant ecological impact. In 2020, the Tamil Nadu government took a stand opposing hydrocarbon projects in coastal areas. The State government should maintain the same stand and not recommend clearance for the project."

In a post on X, PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss said drilling hydrocarbon wells in the Bay of Bengal would severely damage fish stocks and the region's extensive mangrove forests. The move would only lead to more GHG, irreversible environmental damage and threaten the livelihood of fishermen.

"The PMK has successfully pressed for the cancellation of the Cauvery delta region, including several areas in Cuddalore, as a Protected Agricultural Zone, to prevent environmental damage from hydrocarbon projects. HOEC's attempt to prioritise this project outside the boundary of the protected zone, having realised it cannot proceed within the zone limits is highly unacceptable," Dr. Anbumani said.

V.V. Thangamani, president of Cauvery Delta Farmers Federation, said the Tamil Nadu Protected Agricultural Zone Development Act, passed in 2020, prohibited drilling in the region. "But the Centre was trying to wipe out the Cauvery delta, the rice bowl of Tamil Nadu, by introducing the hydrocarbon project. If the project is implemented, its temperatures will rise, damaging the environment," he said. Subsidence exploration can severely impact groundwater and farmers in Chidambaram, Kattumannarkoil, Kurinjipadi, Panruti, and Srimushnam will be unable to use groundwater for farming, and agriculture will collapse, Mr. Thangamani added.

Notices sent to 4 ex-MLAs for defying AIADMK whip during trust vote: Speaker

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

J.C.D. Prabhakar

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar said on Friday that notices were issued on June 9 to four former AIADMK MLAs who voted in favour of the Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay-led government during the confidence vote on May 13, defying the directions of the party whip.

The notices were issued by the Assembly Secretariat to R. Jayakumar, P. Sellapandian, Mr. Raghothaman Kumaravel, and Sasikala Ilango, who were among the 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs who had voted in favour of the TVK-led government and later resigned as legislators and joined the TVK. Barring these four, the remaining 21 rebel MLAs were condoned by AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami after they reconciled themselves with the party.

Speaking to journalists at the Secretariat in Chennai, Mr. Prabhakar said the four former MLAs would have to respond within seven days of the date of issuance of the notices.

Training for MLAs

The Speaker said a training programme would be organised on June 16 and 17 by the Assembly Secretariat at Kilpauk at Anaiyagam in Chennai for all the MLAs to familiarise themselves with Assembly proceedings.

Mr. Vijay will inaugurate the programme, and all legislators, irrespective of their experience, will be involved.

Officials of the Assembly Secretariat and former Assembly Secretaries will conduct sessions on the procedures to be followed at Assembly sessions.

'Measures to prevent CRZ violations, industrial pollution to be stepped up'

Geetha Srinivasan
S. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Rajeev

Minister for Environment and Climate Change Rajeev Ranjan said the government would strictly enforce measures to curb Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) violations, prevent the discharge of untreated industrial effluents into water bodies, and step up monitoring of biomedical waste management.

Speaking to The Hindu, he said complaints regarding CRZ violations along the coast, particularly unauthorised resorts and buildings in ecologically sensitive areas, would be reviewed and acted upon. He said the government would examine existing violations, ascertain when the structures were built, and take action in accordance with the law.

The seriousness of the problem has not been fully understood by everyone," he said.

On industrial pollution, he said industries, particularly dyeing and textile units in western districts, should comply with effluent treatment norms, and violations would invite stringent action. "Our priority is strict enforcement. In some areas, common effluent treatment plants function effectively. We are asking industries elsewhere to establish similar facilities," he said.

Mr. Rajeev said the government was urging industries to invest in efficient treatment infrastructure rather than evading regulations. "Industries should prosper. But they must operate properly because pollution affects women, families, and entire dyeing communities," he said. The Department has planned a scientific assessment of solid waste generation across selected areas to identify waste hotspots and infrastructure gaps, he said.

Facelift to beaches

Mr. Rajeev said Tamil Nadu intended to add more beaches to the Blue Flag programme and upgrade infrastructure at existing sites. Facilities such as washrooms, resting areas, and shaded spaces will be improved, and wooden ramps will also be installed at all existing Blue Flag beaches to improve accessibility and visitor movement, he said. Following the success of the Chief Minister's Cosmic Kuruvi programme, the Minister added that the fellowship, which had 40 fellows in its first batch, had been proposed to be expanded.

AIADMK plans to hold extensive, district-wise consultations shortly

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Edappadi K. Palaniswami

The AIADMK, whose performance during the Assembly elections was the worst in its electoral history over 50 years, is planning to hold extensive and district-wise consultations with its office-bearers and members shortly.

Declaring that, if reasonable functionalities say the proposed 2 lakh seats will be doubled in such a manner that the party's participation in the assembly seats is not diminished. As Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar is to deliver his address to the House on June 15, and the Assembly sit normally soon, to-do days, the party's executives may take place also the session.

Even though it is not known whether the proposed consultations will be on the lines that former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa had done 26 years ago, where party members were encouraged to give their feedback freely, the functionaries among cadres and supporters of the party is that the leadership should have a frank exchange of views with participants.

Objective analysis

Sessions for the poor performance, including constituency-wise during in some parts of the State, should be analysed objectively. Such an exercise will be helpful for the party, which has to face not only by-elections to five Assembly constituencies but also local bodies' polls in eight months, says a researcher of the party.

A perusal of the performance of the party in the Assembly elections reveals that apart from winning in 47 constituencies, the organisation was runner-up in 44 seats and finished third in 81 places. Of the Assembly constituencies where it came second, the party's vote share was at least 30% in 35.

Likewise, in 32 out of 69 seats where it finished third, it secured 25% and more. Among the 69 such constituencies were Kanchipuram, Kurpad, Vandavasi, Nallakrishi, Vaippanallali, Udumalpet, Thiruvaiyaru, Poompuhar, Sholavandan, and Srivaikuntam. The party can, therefore, be encouraged and energy towards strengthening the party in these areas before taking up other issues like raising the pricerise.

While the party can take solace that the highest margin of victory was registered by party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, what should not be glossed over is that the party's vote share increased seats and 40,486 in 2021, and that has now come down to 28.7%. Five years ago, the party contested in 191 seats, whereas this time, the number was 172. The researcher adds that the party, which is still strong in many districts of the State, should make use of the current opportunity here to establish itself as a viable political force.

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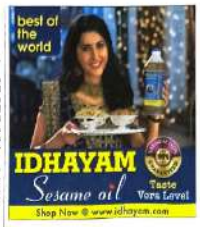
Delta farmers in a quandary on kuruvai cultivation



Water level in Mettur dam

Tiruchi Junction to get six additional escalators by the end of this month

Railway Division takes innovative measure to check accidents at all the 120 non-interlocked level-crossing gates; division will be totally electrified when Pamaluntal-Aranthangi-Karaikudi section traction work is completed in this financial year

Tiruchi Railway Division bags 8 efficiency shields

TIRUCHI TODAY

Blackout at Papanasam railway station for several hours leaves passengers exasperated

In-charge V-C takes charge at CUTN

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No new cases of Nipah in Kozhikode; 3 hospitalised

Ten more added to the updated contact list, taking total number of contacts under surveillance to 87; health workers intensify surveillance measures; NCDC to extend support at the district level

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

No new cases of Nipah virus infection has been detected in Kozhikode district, Kerala Health Minister K. Muraleedharan said on Thursday.

However, three individuals currently under quarantine have been admitted to hospital for observation, and their samples have been sent for testing.

The patient undergoing treatment after testing positive for the virus has been administered the first dose of a monoclonal antibody therapy in accordance with Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) guidelines and on the recommendation of the medical Board.

The Minister said 10 more people had been added to the updated contact list, taking the total number of existing contacts under surveillance to 87 on Friday. Of them, four were categorised as highest-risk contacts, 36 as high-risk and 47 as low-risk contacts.

As part of the intensified field-level surveillance measures, health workers conducted a house-to-house survey in 296 households in ward 5 of the Ramanattukara municipality, where the Nipah case was reported. Twelve persons with fever were identified during the comprehensive survey completed on Friday. None of them exhibited symptoms associated with Nipah infection.

A meeting of the rapid response team was held in Ramanattukara to review the containment zone management plans and surveillance activities. Health Department sources said a team of experts from the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) would soon come up with their scientific field report by assessing the situation and extend their support to the Health Department staff at the district level.

A security guard installing a warning board outside a Nipah isolation ward at the Government Medical College Hospital, Kozhikode, on Friday.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select centres yesterday

Forecast for 24 hrs from 8.30 a.m. today: Very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Odisha and Kerala; heat wave conditions likely at isolated pockets over Telangana, Marathwada and Rajasthan; and dry to very dry weather likely at isolated pockets over Maharashtra and Konkan & Goa

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Kollur Mookambika Temple in Udupi district on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.N. CM Vijay visits Kollur Mookambika Temple, offers sword

The Hindu Bureau
MANGALURU

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay visited the Kollur Mookambika Temple in Udupi district of Karnataka on Friday and offered a silver sword to the presiding deity.

This is his first visit to Karnataka since taking charge as the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister.

Sources said the sword weighed 1.6 kg. He offered a special puja at the temple in the afternoon.

Security tightened

The police had beefed up security at the temple in view of his visit. The temple wore a deserted look due to the security arrangements.

After visiting the temple, Mr. Vijay drove to the Mookambika guest house at Kollur.

Sources at the Mangaluru airport said the Chief Minister had driven the car himself while returning to the airport from Kollur.

He waved at his fans and boarded the special flight to Chennai at 6.30 p.m.

Earlier, Mr. Vijay arrived at the airport by a special flight from Delhi around 1 p.m. Minister for Health and Family Welfare U.T. Khader and officials of the Dakshina Kannada district administration welcomed him at the airport.

The officials presented him with two books at the airport. He left for Kollur via Udupi by road.

Black flag protest

Before Mr. Vijay could reach Udupi, a group of activists of the Karnataka Rakshana Vedike (Praveen Kumar Shetty faction) gathered at Udyavara on National Highway no. 66 in Udupi to show black flag to the Chief Minister.

The activists were opposing Tamil Nadu raising objection to the proposed Mekedatu irrigation project.

They were taken into preventive custody by the police.

ED issues fresh summons to Pinarayi's daughter Veena in CMRL pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has reportedly issued a fresh summons to Veena T., daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, asking her to appear at its Kochi office on June 17 in connection with the probe into the alleged pay-off case involving Exalogic Solutions Private Limited, Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm, and Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL).

She was supposed to appear before the ED for questioning on Friday. The fresh summons comes in the wake of her request to postpone her appearance citing health grounds. She is supposed to appear at 10 a.m. with relevant documents.

The ED had summoned Ms. Veena along with Sasidharan Kartha, chairman and managing director of CMRL, and senior company officials on June 9 as part of the probe. The officers have been asked to appear on June 15.

The ED had on May 27 raided the residences of Mr. Vijayan as part of the probe into whether Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm had received sizeable monthly retainers from the CMRL, a public limited company, during the 2017-2020 period allegedly without rendering any tangible service. It has also been accused that Exalogic India Capital Investments Private Ltd., operated by Mr. Kartha, had extended loans worth ₹50 lakh to Exalogic despite it allegedly failing to make timely repayments.

During the course of the raids, the ED had frozen ₹98.36 crore.

Check drugs, narcotics trafficking, T.N. Minister tells officials

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUCHI

S. Ramesh, Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE), greeting the participants at the review meeting on 'Go to Collectorate on Friday' at Tiruchi

Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments S. Ramesh on Friday urged the officials of various departments to take steps to check the movement and use of banned drugs and narcotics in the district.

Chairing a review meeting with officials, Mr. Ramesh said the State government had committed to safeguard the people from drug abuse.

There was a need for enhanced vigil against illegal sale of drugs and banned tobacco items.

The officials concerned should take steps against those responsible for it.

He said importance should be given to creating necessary infrastructure such as drinking water supply, roads, bridges, sanitation facilities and so on. Attention should be paid to environment protection, solid waste management, and cleanliness. Government schemes should be implemented in a transparent manner and on time. Officials should utilise digital technology to offer various services to the people.

Later, the Minister said that he would review the progress of various schemes with the officials once in a month.

Deputy Speaker M. Ranjithkar, Collector Pratik Dayal, Commissioner of Police N. Kamini, Corporation Commissioner Veer Pratap Singh, Additional Collector (Development) T. Sneha, Superintendent of Police Jayagowri Pratik Umesh, and senior officials of various departments were present.

Naidu slams YSRCP for 'spewing venom' against NDA; hails Centre's support

A.D. Rangaraju
TIRUPATI

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister and Telugu Desam Party (TDP) national president Nara Chandrababu Naidu has flayed the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP), accusing it of systematically unleashing a negative campaign against the NDA regime in an apparent bid to portray the State in poor light.

Addressing a public meeting on Friday organised at Donimedu to celebrate two years of the NDA rule in the State and 12 years of the NDA rule at the Centre, he lambasted the YSRCP for "spewing venom against the alliance regime and filling the people's mind with confusion and disbelief".

"We are focusing on taking the fruits of development to the people. But the YSRCP is working on a single-point agenda of spreading lies and unfounded charges among the public," Mr. Naidu said.

He alleged that the YSRCP's social media wing was trying hard to promote suspicion and hatred against the ruling dispensation by spreading misinformation.

Recalling the stand taken by the YSRCP ahead of the 2019 election, such as implementing rural prohibition, recall of Constituency Pension Scheme (CPS), announcement of job calendar every year and support for Amaravati as the State's capital, Mr. Naidu wondered if it had fulfilled at least one of the above. "On the other hand, they are doing everything to bring disrepute to us, solely out of frustration," he charged.

Rebuilding Amaravati

"They divided the districts in an irresponsible manner, connected it by forming Markapuram, Nadanagiri and Polavaram. They had absurdly brought Land Titling Act. We initiated resurvey exercise to solve land disputes. They created the three capitals drama, but we are rebuilding Amaravati," Mr. Naidu said.

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Identify inmates languishing in jails despite acquittal, HC tells T.N. govt.

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Coming across a case where a person acquitted of all charges after his mental health condition was ascertained continues to languish in jail for the last 30 years, the Madurai Bench of Madras High Court has directed the State government to conduct an inspection and ascertain whether similar such persons were languishing in jails across the State.

The order was hearing a petition filed by the man's brother from Ariyalur district.

The petitioner's brother suffered from paranoid schizophrenia and was accused of hacking their mother to death in 2006 following a quarrel with their parents.

Mahila Court in Ariyalur, on ascertaining the mental health status of the accused, came to a conclusion that he was suffering from chronic mental health condition and acquitted him of all charges.

While acquitting him, the trial court directed him to be detained in Tiruchi Central Prison till the State government decides to release the accused to any of his friends or relatives.

The grievance of the petitioner was that for the last 20 years, his brother continues to be inside Tiruchi Central Prison.

A Division Bench of Justices N. Anand Venkatesh and K.K. Ramakrishnan said this was one of the most unfortunate cases where an accused person after having been acquitted from all charges continues to languish in jail for the last two years. This was the height of violation under Article 21 of the Constitution.

If really the person concerned was suffering from a chronic mental health condition, to ensure his protection and in the interest of society, he has to be placed in a Mental Health Institute and he cannot be detained in a jail.

The court posted the matter for hearing on June 17.

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Strategic stalemate

The U.S. should lift the blockade before asking Iran to open the Hormuz Strait

President Donald Trump's decision to back off from striking Iran, just hours after threatening to seize the country's Kharg Island, underscores the dilemma he faces in dealing with Tehran. Mr. Trump, who launched the conflict with his ally Benjamin Netanyahu's backing on February 28, now wants to end it through talks. But Iran, which survived 40 days of U.S.-Israeli bombing and now controls the Strait of Hormuz, appears unwilling to bend him a diplomatic victory. Caught between an inconsolable Israel, whose bombing of Lebanon threatens the fragile U.S.-Iran ceasefire, and an emboldened Iran that has become increasingly defiant and intransigent, Mr. Trump reverted to his familiar playbook of using military pressure to alter Tehran's negotiating position. On Wednesday, he ordered strikes on Iran after confirming that a U.S. Apache helicopter had been shot down over the Strait of Hormuz. Iran retaliated by striking U.S. bases in Kuwait, Bahrain and Jordan. After two nights of tit-for-tat strikes, Mr. Trump backed off on Thursday, claiming progress in talks. Over the past two months, he has claimed dozens of times that a deal with Iran was within reach. In the war's escalation cycle, Mr. Trump takes a new step forward, two steps back.

When Mr. Trump despatched Mr. Witkoff to Iran's shores in February, he wanted to force Tehran into surrender through military pressure. The U.S. and Israel had an ambitious list of demands, including dismantling Iran's nuclear programme, degrading its missile capabilities and ending its support for non-state militias. When the U.S. and Israel launched the war, they wanted regime change in Tehran. More than three months later, the war, which failed to achieve any of the declared objectives, has hardened Iran's positions. Tehran was willing to make concessions on its nuclear programme on February 27. It now insists that any discussion on the nuclear file can take place only after the U.S.-Israeli hostilities cease and the blockade is lifted. The war has fundamentally altered the strategic reality of the region. Yet, Iran has absorbed significant military and economic costs, but it has emerged strategically stronger by taking control of the Hormuz Strait and effectively crippling the U.S. economy in the process. Rather than eliding a deep-rooted Iranian surrender, Washington should adopt a phased, realistic diplomatic approach. The priority should be to enforce and extend the ceasefire imposed from and let the blockade to endure for Iran reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Once safety is restored, both sides can return to substantive talks on Iran's nuclear programme and work towards a durable end to the conflict.

Long overdue

Coal exchanges can balance out energy scarcities across India

Unveiled at a time of record domestic coal production, the Coal Exchange Rules, 2026, are a case of better late than never. They will create a broad market-based mechanism through regulated trading platforms for the lynchpin of India's energy system — coal. They are aimed at enhancing price discovery, transparency, access for small consumers, as well as, one would hope, reduce bilateral agreements that are often opaque and come with a whiff of graft, too often. Today, most coal transactions between producers and buyers take place through long-term contracts, primarily for the power sector, followed by auctions, imports and captive mining. While India's commodity exchanges are well established, they function largely as financial markets rather than physical delivery platforms. Coal exchanges, however, report poor price discovery in power exchanges, which, despite modest volumes, play a role in price discovery, market signalling and the development of secondary markets. And to prove this point, coal exchanges are expected to serve the non-regulated sector, which relies on Coal India auctions where coal is often sold at a premium in the highest bidder. Power exchanges are not merely viable trading platforms, they serve as points of reference for the broader power market. They have enhanced price discovery and served as a balancing market without replacing long-term power purchase agreements. It adds the power exchanges were also balancing shortages, but eventually the spot prices became a function of the broader power market indicating scarcity, surplus and system stresses for all electricity stakeholders. Perhaps the key role coal exchanges could be to open up new avenues for other players to balance out shortages across India.

The templates for the two exchanges are not very different, though the specific rules framed by the Coal Controller Organisation of India will determine the success of coal exchanges. Just as with the successes, the failures of power exchanges — in also some sectors hamstrung for coal — is not acceptable as electricity, which are generated in the same eco-system requiring only minimum standards. Coal quality varies widely. Therefore, robust standards and quality measures are as important as contract design. It should require strict enforcement. The three key elements will ensure that the major producers and the consumers are drawn to the coal exchanges. The emphasis should be on involving power producers — particularly smaller power exchanges, which are dominated by discoms. Coal India's access to the critical Bridge linkages with spatial volatility, despite the coal-rich eastern and central transportation logistics will be important. The three key coal exchanges will be physical delivery platforms

Equality of treatment for Persons with Disabilities

Addressing the digital divide through the Digital India Mission, India has manifested its interests becoming a global "best practice" model of a digital welfare state. Yet, persons with disabilities (PwDs) remain largely excluded from this transformative moment and outreach. Disability pensions, meanwhile, are determined not only by the nature or extent of disability but by the discretionary decisions of State governments, and cumbersome bureaucratic processes. As a result, a substantial section of citizens continues to remain outside the ambit of a welfare architecture that otherwise prides itself on inclusivity and last-mile delivery.

Sushil Kumar
Former Secretary, Department of Justice and an Advocate in the Supreme Court and High Court

An inadequate safety net

The 2011 Census recorded 2.68 crore PwDs. The 2026 Census recorded 2.68 crore PwDs. The 2011 Census recorded 2.68 crore persons. Although the Supreme Court of India has recognised the right to live with dignity as a fundamental right and the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 provides legal protection, disability benefits — especially pensions — remain fragmented, discretionary, and inadequate. As a result, the Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme covers only a small fraction of PwDs, while pension amounts in most States range from just ₹300 to ₹500 a month, with a few offering ₹1,000-2,000.

India spends barely 0.03% of GDP on disability welfare including pensions. South Africa spends 0.12%-0.15% of GDP on disability pensions more. Brazil it 0.45%-0.50% (20 times more); OECD countries 2.2% (100 times more) and Australia 0.38%-0.40% (20 times more).

Beyond politics, sound economics demands the inclusion of PwDs. The World Bank and UNDP estimate that low and middle-income countries lose 3%-7% of GDP when PwDs are excluded from education, employment, and social security. Disability income improves household stability, rural consumption, and labour participation. Studies show fiscal multipliers of 1.4-1.6, while the 2015 Pro Bono Economics report found that the socio-economic returns from disability pensions exceed their costs by nearly 40%. Far from being a welfare expense, disability pensions are an investment and an effective economic stimulus.

India must adopt a minimum universal disability pension floor rate

India must establish a Minimum Universal Disability Pension Floor Rate (MUDPFR) to give effect to the State's constitutional obligation, under Article 41, to provide public assistance to persons with disabilities, and to operationalise Section 24 of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, which guarantees adequate social security, including pension benefits. Such a measure would translate the promise of inclusive growth and "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas" into reality by shifting disability pensions from a matter of charity and discretion to a matter of entitlement and rights, while ensuring that an extremely disabled person receives less than a minimum pension regardless of where they live. A MUDPFR would still allow States to provide additional top-ups.

This is not an unrealistic proposal. South Africa provides a national disability grant with uniform eligibility norms; Brazil's BPC guarantees a national minimum income; and Australia and New Zealand operate nationwide disability pension systems. Several developing countries, including Kenya, Rwanda, Thailand and Indonesia, also provide disability income support at the national level. International experience shows that centrally set standards promote uniformity, universality and portability.

A MUDPFR of ₹6,000 per month for 40 lakh beneficiaries would cost about ₹28,619 crore annually or 0.08% of GDP, while ₹10,000 for 65 lakh beneficiaries would cost ₹78,000 crore. Even such beneficiaries would cost ₹78,000 crore. Even such beneficiaries would cost ₹78,000 crore. Even such

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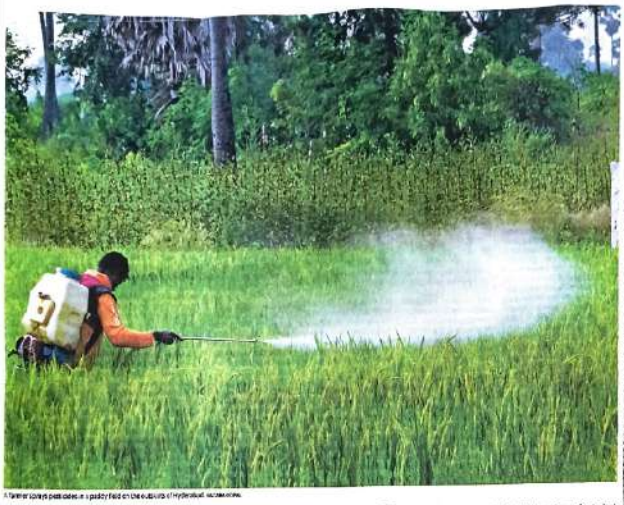

A farmer sprays pesticides in a paddy field on the outskirts of Hyderabad. VIJENDRA KUMAR

The human cost of a deadly weed killer

In March, Telangana banned paraquat, one of the world's most widely used and highly toxic weedkillers, becoming only the third State in India to do so. The herbicide is responsible for hundreds of deaths each year, most of them suicides and some accidental. Srrish Nanisetti reports on the campaign that led to the ban and why much more remains to be done

At 50, Baresh Goud (name changed) has lived to tell a tale. "I may look normal, but I become breathless when I climb stairs or even walk more than five minutes. The doctor says my lungs got affected," he says.

About three years ago, on a sweltering afternoon, Goud opened his refrigerator, took out a small plastic bottle labelled with a popular juice brand, and took a sip. The drink did not have the usual sugary, tart apple flavour that he was used to; instead, it tasted flat. He began vomiting.

Goud did not know that he had drunk paraquat, a highly toxic herbicide and one of the most effective weed killers in the world. Paraquat, a colourless and tasteless liquid, is most often fatal for both humans and animals.

It was a mistake that resulted in Goud fighting for his life. "I had asked my nephew to get the grass inside the local nursery for weeds to grow in front of our house," he recalls.

"He kept the bottle on a table inside the house. My wife thought it was a cool drink and placed it inside the fridge." While wholesale traders store paraquat in drums, farmers and others often follow a risky routine with the weedicide.

Goud was rushed from his house in Pulkurthi to a hospital in Nizamabad, about 15 kilometres away. The doctors were sure he would die.

Being an employee of TSGENCO (Telangana State Power Generation Corporation Limited), Goud had an ESIC (Employee State Insurance Corporation) card, necessary for workers below a certain salary level to access free medical care and financial benefits at ESIC dispensaries and hospitals across the State. He was quickly ferried to an ambulance to a tertiary care facility in Hyderabad, roughly 185 km away.

Dr. Nirmala Addanki, a General Medicine practitioner, learned that Goud had a "paraquat mouth" — the severe, corrosive damage that occurs when a person swallows or is exposed to paraquat — and put him on continuous renal replacement therapy (CRRT). Over the next 60 days, Goud's condition slowly improved.

"His family had given up on him," remembers Dr. Addanki. "But we persisted and he had the will to survive too. Now, he has photographs of his family as his WhatsApp display picture."

On March 31, 2026, Telangana banned the sale, distribution, manufacture, and use of paraquat, to protect the safety and health of people, especially farmers. It became only the third State to do so, after Kerala and Odisha. The Government Order was issued days after intense lobbying by doctors, civil society, and public representatives calling for the ban of the weedicide, which has been often used for self-harm. Neighbouring Andhra Pradesh followed suit in May.

Ban and loss-ups

Paraquat was already banned due to its fatal toxic potential. But farms, easy availability, low price (₹260 per litre), and widespread use in India. The only law to regulate hazardous chemicals such as paraquat is the Insecticides Act, 1968.

Goud's story is an exception: the weedicide has killed thousands of people, as is evident from autopsy reports from hospitals across the world. Paraquat is banned in 76 countries. In India, Kerala became the first State to ban it in 2011. However, in February 2022, the Kerala High Court overturned the ban following a plea by a cardamom growers' collective. While the Kerala Agriculture Department's notification specifically named the chemical along with 18 others, the High Court struck down the ban on the technical ground that the State did not have the authority to enforce it beyond 60-100 days (as per Section 29 of the Insecticides Act).

In October 2002, Kerala was rocked by the murder of Shyron Kal, who was allegedly poisoned with a paraquat-laced drink by his fiancée, Greeshma. He died at the Medical College Hospital in Thiruvananthapuram, triggering a public uproar as details of the case quickly emerged in the public domain.

"We can still order it online," says Dileep Kumar of Pesticide Action Network, a global coalition of over 600 NGOs, institutions, and individuals across 90 countries dedicated to eliminating hazardous chemical pesticides. "A ban by one State without the involvement of e-commerce sites is just a ban on paper. It is ineffectual," he points out.

Kumar adds that the country needs stronger laws and regulations to manage this crisis. "Even the Bhopal gas tragedy [in 1984] did not lead to new laws to regulate pesticides," he says.

The problem is not just limited regulation of pesticides, weedicides, and insecticides; it is also low awareness about safe use. According to a statement by the Minister of State for Agriculture in the Lok Sabha, Nimisha Jaiswal, 1,703 farmers were made aware of the safe and judicious use of pesticides between 2018 and 2026. This is a low figure in a country where 46.1% of the population is dependent on agriculture, as per the Economic Survey of 2025-26.

As per the Act, the ban in Telangana was for 60 days and can be extended by 30 more days. On the day that the Telangana issued a Government Order imposing a ban on paraquat, the Legislative Assembly passed a bipartisan resolution asking the Central government to ban the chemical across the country.

Lobbying for a ban

On the afternoon of February 12, Dr. Murri Mahesh Reddy, the founder of a grassroots movement called Doctors Against Paraquat, called for a gathering of farmers in Kothuram village in Karimnagar. The emerald green village, with endless paddy fields, is on the eastern side of the Sriramsagar flood flow canal that carries water from the Godavari river. The wildlife sanctuary and meeting with farmers was part of a campaign by Dr. Reddy.

"If we don't use this, can't we do agriculture?" Dr. Reddy said, addressing the gathering. "Didn't we do agriculture before this?" Brush-cutter less, eye-mantida less. Easy safer seasonal? engages? (We have brush cutters, trifolate, and other chemicals. Why use this toxic substance?)"

He explained what made paraquat particularly dangerous. "I used to get emergency cases of snake bites and poisoning," he said. "There were antidotes for snakebites and the centres was not always in stock. But paraquat is in a different league. It destroys the cell structure and there is no antidote."

Doctors Against Paraquat comprises 200 doctors drawn from different parts of Telangana, who lobbied with politicians, farmers, and bureaucrats relentlessly for a ban on paraquat. Using social media and personal connections, Dr. Reddy reached out to the Telangana Chief Minister's Office, the Prime Minister's Office, and politicians.

Yes, Parkinson and other farming villages have found paraquat useful. As labour shortage is rising and the cost of hiring farm workers is increasing, farmers use paraquat, which is labelled and sold as non-selective contact herbicide (meaning, it does not differentiate between one plant and another), to clean up residual plants and weeds. Paraquat imports to India rose from 8,551 tonnes in 2018-20 to 20,786 tonnes in 2022-23, according to the Lok Sabha Unstarred Question No. 2242 to the Minister of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare in 2025.

"Without any oversight or intervention by officials from the agriculture department, there is a runaway use of paraquat in most parts of the country. There are many accidental deaths due to careless use as well," says Kadanda Reddy, Chairperson of the Telangana Agriculture Farmers' Welfare Corporation, who has also worked to get the ban imposed in the State.

"Currently we are seeing web e-commerce companies as well as other channels also to ensure that the product is not available in online stores," he adds. The lobbying appears to have paid off, as Nesha e-commerce sites — Flipkart and Amazon — no longer list the chemical in Telangana. However, it is easily available from smaller agriculture and nursery sites.

A rush to save patients

Bodies are constantly wheeled in and out of the Department of Forensic Medicine, Toxicology and Autopsy Complex at Gandhi Hospital in Hyderabad, where 46.1% of the population is dependent on agriculture, as per the Economic Survey of 2025-26.

Ambulances waiting outside the Gandhi Hospital in Hyderabad, where 46.1% of the population is dependent on agriculture, as per the Economic Survey of 2025-26. NAGARA GOPAL

Without any oversight or intervention by officials from the agriculture department, there is a runaway use of paraquat in most parts of the country.

KUDADA REDDY
Chairperson of the Telangana Agriculture Farmers Welfare Corporation

Hyderabad. Families wait in grief and the police mill around. There is an overpowering odour of bleach, ether, and putrefying flesh.

The toll of paraquat poisoning is evident here. According to Dr. Anand Vivek Sai Ramvi, Doctor of Medicine dissertation, "An autopsy based study on deaths due to Paraquat poisoning in Gandhi Hospital, the facility recorded 217 cases of paraquat poisoning in 2020 and 2025. Of these, 54% of the patients were farmers and 16% students. Of the 200 cases studied for the dissertation, 94% were suicide cases and 3% were accidental.

"There is no treatment for paraquat poisoning, no antidote. We only receive clues from the family when bottles with labels are found near the victim or there is an oral statement," says Dr. Krupal Singh, the head of department of Forensic Medicine and Toxicology. He is also part of Doctors Against Paraquat.

"All we can do is symptomatic treatment," Dr. Singh adds. "As a result, treatment remains largely supportive, focusing on early gastrointestinal decontamination, organ support, and prevention of further oxidative damage. If the patient is put on a ventilator, the progress of the chemical is accelerated, with multiple organ failure and fibrosis of lungs being irreversible."

Inside the nephrology ward of the century-old Osmania General Hospital in Hyderabad, patients sit in rows. "Every month, we get 4-5 paraquat-related cases. Most of the patients die within days," says Dr. Manisha Shenoy, Head of the Nephrology Department, who is the first doctor to be called in once a patient suspected of ingesting paraquat is wheeled into the hospital.

"The prognosis is bleak even with advanced treatment like CRRT," she explains. "The chemical causes rapid damage, first to the kidneys, then the liver, and eventually the lungs. Irrelevant of a person on a ventilator accelerates damage to the lungs." She does not remember any survivors.

Poor regulatory efforts

While the dangers of paraquat and its misuse have drawn global attention, regulatory efforts in India have largely escaped public scrutiny.

Paraquat's origins date back to the 1880s, when it was first developed as a chemical dye. Its herbicidal properties were discovered in the 1950s, and Imperial Chemical Industries began marketing it as Gramoxone in the 1960s. Concerns about its toxicity surfaced early in India. In 1968, G. Vijaya Rama Raju, a doctor from Siddipet, raised the issue in the Lok Sabha, but the Agriculture Minister said the government had received no reports of harmful effects.

However, Imperial Chemical Industries documents suggest the company was aware of the risks. An agenda paper by the company dated November 10, 1987, and accessed by *The Hindu*, noted: "Suicidal abuse of the product will not be eliminated." According to the paper, the company also chose not to dilute the chemical to make it safer, calculating that this would increase packaging size fivefold. It noted that "usage by farmers would reduce significantly because of bulk / preservation/higher prices."

During these years, Imperial Chemical Industries was earning significant revenues from paraquat. In 1987, sales of the product reached 15,000 tonnes, generating ₹382 million, according to a document from October 4, 1988, accessed by *The Hindu*.

In August 2025, the Lok Sabha was informed that there are 1,703 licensed manufacturers of paraquat in the country. While Telangana banned the herbicide on March 31, on April 16, the Central Insecticides Board and Registration Committee, at its 478th meeting, cleared seven applications for formulation under indigenous manufacture as "satisfactory."

India has not been a passive player in the ongoing stories of paraquat. It has also, at times, been an enabler in its continued use. In May 2019, India joined Guatemala in opposing the listing of paraquat as a "severely hazardous pesticide formulation" under Annex III of the Rotterdam Convention, a multi-lateral environmental agreement. Such a listing would not have led to a banning of the chemical, but it would have required importing countries to notify and obtain prior consent from importing countries before shipment. The proposal was supported by 58 countries but did not go through because the treaty's voting rules require complete consensus.

Dagdi Prabhakar, representing 17 agro-chemical companies, said in *The Hindu*, "Studies by institutions on paraquat dichloride and carbosulfan, also a Kharif sowing begins, could raise input costs, disrupt crop protection, and deepen farmer vulnerability." Paraquat is used on nearly 80 lakh acres in India and remains a low-cost weed-control option for small farmers, he added.

In Karimnagar, however, the ban has already had a visible impact. "Deaths due to paraquat have decreased from around 30-50 per month before the ban to 3-5 now, according to data from pulmonologists and nephrologists," says Dr. Reddy. "We can reach zero deaths if the ban is imposed across the country and the chemical is removed from shelves and storerooms. Aldercrats will have to make it easier if this happens.

Those in distress or having suicidal tendencies could seek help and counselling by calling any of the following numbers: 104 / 18890 14554

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From Page One

Attacks on ships 'unacceptable': India

At the time ships were, however, in their return voyage, not leaving the area.

The U.S. envoy was called in by Nagaraj Naidu Kakarla, Additional Secretary (Americas) in the Ministry.

The summoning of Mr. Hoek came hours before Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to take off for France where he is expected to meet Mr. Trump on the sidelines of the G7 summit.

Following the G7 summit, India is poised to host the 20th Meeting of the IORA Committee of Senior Officials (CSO) on June 15-16 where the matter of attacks on civilians working on merchant vessels and oil tankers operating in the Indian Ocean are likely to be there. The CSO is the second highest decision-making body of IORA and includes senior government representatives from the member states.

Strong Indian links

Shipping experts say many Indian-owned and operated ships catering to India's oil needs served by Russian and, to a smaller extent, Iranian oil. Since the US has imposed sanctions on the two countries, these ships are registered in countries that are called 'flags of convenience' with minimum scrutiny and oversight. Using such flags and frequent changes of names, flags and ownership are a feature of such ships, globally.

Food prices push up retail inflation to 3.9%

The higher print was observed both in headline and core inflation. The latter too increased to 3.70% marking three consecutive records of quickening price rise. Core inflation is calculated without considering food, fuel and electricity prices.

The increase can be largely attributed to improvement in food prices, with the Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI) inflation at 4.8% in May 2026, ending up from 4.2% in the previous month.

Several food staples experienced a faster rate of inflation or a lowering rate of deflation. Cereal prices increased 0.38% among the positive territory for the first time since January 2026, from which the new 2024 series is available. Most of the increase came from rice, prices of which increased 0.22% after staying in deflation territory since the beginning of the calendar year.

SC dismisses Natarajan's plea on RS nomination

The Bench, however, held that recognising an exception for "clerical" or "patent" errors in the rejection of nomination papers would amount to reading into Article 329 a "principle" that does not exist. It noted that such an approach would run contrary to the law laid down in its 1950 judgment in *N.P. Ponnuswami v. RO*, which bars the invocation of writ jurisdiction to challenge disputes arising during the course of an election.

"... If this Court accepts such an argument to find out glaring cases which are required to be interfered with under Article 32 or Article 226 of the Constitution of India and the other set of cases in which the rejection is not so improper or fatal as, relegating them to avail the remedy of filing an election petition, this Court will be creating some principle which is not provided for under Article 329 of the Constitution. We are afraid this any such interpretation that, in some cases, the court may interfere where a candidate's nomination paper is wrongly rejected, while leaving some others to file an election petition, cannot be accepted," the Bench underlined. The senior counsel also questioned the poll body's decision to proceed with the declaration of results on Thursday despite the top court being cognisant of the matter.

AI-171 crash: AAIB puts out interim statement

It said the investigation remained current and a detailed examination of all aspects of the accident, including technical, operational, organisational and human factors.

The UK's aviation safety watchdog's Annex 13 on Aircraft Accident and Incident Investigation says that states must bring out a final report as soon as possible, and if possible, within 12 months. Otherwise they must publish an interim statement on each anniversary of the accidents.

A preliminary investigation report into the crash found that an aircraft's fuel control switches had moved to the cut-off position, interrupting fuel supply to the engines moments before the crash. While the report stopped short of determining whether the pilots' movement was the result of a deliberate action or inadvertently done or due to a malfunction, it included a brief cockpit exchange between the pilots in two pilots that has triggered widespread speculation in the case of the accident.

Pilot associations have condemned the leaking of the transcript, arguing that it has contributed to the hardening of a narrative around pilot involvement before the investigation reached a definitive conclusion.

BSF, BGB discuss 'illegal, forced' border crossings

Border-guarding forces of India and Bangladesh also reviewed steps to check human trafficking and smuggling of narcotics during the four-day D-G-level coordination conference held in Delhi

Vijeta Singh
NEW DELHI

The Border Security Force and the Border Guard Bangladesh discussed "illegal and forced border crossings", among other issues, pertaining to the India-Bangladesh border during the four-day talks that concluded on Thursday, a BSF statement said.

The 55th Director General-Level Border Coordination Conference between the border-guarding forces of India and Bangladesh was held in Delhi from June 6 to 11.

"During the deliberations, both sides held detailed discussions on measures to effectively prevent trans-border crimes, including smuggling of narcotics, arms, counterfeit currency, gold and other contraband, as well as illegal border crossings and human trafficking. The two delegations also discussed issues relating to border deaths and illegal/unauthorised/forcible crossing at the border areas, construction of border infrastructure, implementation of the Coordinated Border Management Plan, confidence-building measures and the need for closer cooperation in addressing emerging security challenges along the borders," the BSF statement said.

The conference was a continuation of the Director Generals' Border Coordination Conference held in Dhaka in December 2025. | Photo Credit: BSF

BSF 'pushbacks'

Unlike in the past, when D-G-level meetings were followed by a press conference, this time, only a statement was issued by the BSF. Over the past month, there have been multiple incidents of undocumented persons, suspected to be from Bangladesh, being sent across the border on foot, only to be stopped by the BSF. The reported "pushback" of undocumented persons, not restricted to the West Bengal border but also along the Meghalaya, Tripura, and Assam borders, has resulted in confrontations between the BSF and BGB personnel at several border points.

The conference also been reports of some thawing along some of these stretches.

While Bangladesh has refused to accept the undocumented persons, questioning their nationality, the BSF has maintained that they had entered India illegally and were carrying documents indicating Bangladeshi nationality.

'Deep concern'

A BGB statement said that the "D-G, BGB expressed deep concern, particularly over the recent incidents of pushing of individuals, including Rohingya/Myanmar nationals and Indian nationals, into Bangladesh by the BSF" It stated that the pushing of these "pushed-in" Indian/Indians at the border was inhumane and many of them were in distress, suffering from hunger and illness, and include elderly persons requiring urgent medical attention.

The BGB reiterated that Bangladesh does not allow Rohingya or Myanmar nationals to use its territory for illegal entry into India.

The Indian delegation was led by BSF D-G Praveen Kumar while the Bangladesh delegation was led by BGB D-G Major General Mohammad Ashrafuzzaman Siddiqui.

"The conference has been conducted in a cordial, positive, and forward-looking atmosphere, reaffirming the enduring cooperation and mutual trust between the two border guarding forces," the BSF statement said.

"Emphasis was also laid on sensitising border population about the sanctity of the international boundary and promoting greater public awareness to prevent illegal activities in border areas," it said.

Trivedi set to take charge as India's envoy to Bangladesh

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

Dinesh Trivedi

Democracies are bound to have issues and disputes, and such differences should be resolved through interactions and dialogue, India's High Commissioner-designate to Bangladesh, Dinesh Trivedi, said on Friday.

Speaking to pressperson soon after crossing from West Bengal's Petrapole to Bangladesh's Benapole, Mr. Trivedi called for cooperation in sectors such as health, technology, and education, and advocated turning the two countries into a powerful economic bloc.

"We will proceed together by combining the hundred forty crore people of India and the twenty crore people of Bangladesh. Bangladesh and India are both strong democracies and in democracies there are bound to be issues but there has to be interactions to deal with them which is necessary. I will carry out my responsibilities in that context," Mr. Trivedi said in Benapole.

"We cannot become powerful in isolation from each other. Technology, education, health, and sports are areas where we can work together and beat the world," he said, urging the media in Bangladesh to project the continued strength of the people relations of India and Bangladesh. The relationship between the two countries has remained strained since the uprising of August 2024 that overthrew the government of Sheikh Hasina, who remains in India.

Meeting in Bangladesh

Mr. Trivedi is a former Union Minister for Railways and Health and Family Welfare and a three-term member of the Rajya Sabha. He is currently a member of the Bharatiya Janata Party in West Bengal, and was appointed India's High Commissioner to Bangladesh on April 21. He is expected to present his credentials to Bangladesh President Mohammed Shahabuddin shortly.

Lt.-Gen. Rajiv Ghai appointed Military Adviser to NSCS

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lieutenant-General Rajiv Ghai

Lieutenant-General Rajiv Ghai, who is currently serving as the Deputy Chief of the Indian Army and who spearheaded military operations as Director-General of Military Operations (DGMO) during Operation Sindoor last year, has been appointed the new Military Adviser (MA) to the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS).

This marks the first time that a serving military officer has been appointed Military Adviser to the NSCS, which functions under National Security Adviser Ajit Doval.

Lieutenant-General Ghai, whose tenure is service extends till December 2027, was appointed to the post earlier this week. He is expected to assume charge shortly. The position was previously held by General N.S. Raja Subramani before he was appointed Chief of Defence Staff. Prior to him, the post was occupied by Air Marshal Sandeep Singh and, earlier, by General Anil Chauhan.

Commissioned into the Kumaon Regiment, Lieutenant General Ghai has held several key operational and command appointments during his distinguished military career. His appointment is being seen as a significant move aimed at strengthening military inputs and operational expertise within the country's highest national security decision-making framework.

Amit Shah reviews security plans for Amarnath Yatra

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amit Shah (Centre), J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha (Right) and National Security Advisor Ajit Doval (Left). PTI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah reviewed the security arrangements for the upcoming Amarnath Yatra in Jammu and Kashmir on Friday. He directed the officials to ensure robust security arrangements at other major tourist destinations besides the Yatra route. The Yatra is scheduled to be held from July 3 to August 28.

After the April 2025 terror strike at Baisaran Valley in Pahalgam, where 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed, several tourist spots in J&K were shut down for security audit.

The meeting was attended by J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval, Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi, Director of the Intelligence Bureau (IB) Tapan Kumar Deka, BSF Director-General of Police Nalin Prabhat, the Directors-General of the Central Reserve Police Forces (CRPF), and senior officials from the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Indian Army, and the Union Territory of J&K.

'Multi-layered security'

Mr. Shah instructed the officials that an integrated and impregnable security cover be put in place for the Yatra through the coordinated efforts of all security agencies. He said that the traditional security framework should be strengthened through the extensive use of modern technologies such as drones, CCTV surveillance, advanced monitoring systems, and other technological tools. He also said that a multi-layered security grid should be established along the Yatra route by J&K Police, CAPFs, and other security agencies.

He also emphasised that adequate arrangements must be ensured for all essential services, including pilgrim registration, accommodation, healthcare facilities, and disaster management. He said the movement of pilgrims should be regulated in accordance with prevailing weather forecasts.

Bodies of two Naga hostages identified; UNC wants peace deal scrapped

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The bodies of two Naga hostages — among six Naga villagers who were allegedly abducted and killed by armed Kuki groups in Manipur — have been identified.

The United Naga Council (UNC), the apex body in Manipur's Naga-inhabited hills, said that the bodies had been identified on the basis of the Jawaharlal Nehru Institute of Medical Sciences (JNIMS) autopsy in Imphal.

"We came to know that the bodies of the two victims, both pastors, were identified based on their dresses. The other bodies have not been identified yet, as they are highly mutilated and disfigured," said A.C. Thou, the UNC's working committee secretary.

'Kuki SoO pact'

On Friday, the UNC sent a memorandum to Union Home Minister Amit Shah demanding the abrogation of the Centre's Suspension of Operations agreement signed with 25 Kuki and Zomi armed groups.

The Naga apex body also demanded the immediate arrest and prosecution of the members of the Kuki National Front (Democratic) group, who were allegedly involved in the abduction of 10 Naga civilians at Leilon Vaiphai village in Kangpokpi district last month.

The UNC also demanded the arrest and prosecution of Kuki militants, the chief of Leilon Vaiphai village, and other villagers for their alleged involvement in the abduction of the 10 Nagas and the "cold-blooded murder" of six of them.

The UNC further accused a serving superintendent of police of involvement in the abduction and murder of the Naga civilians.

Project Kusha, our indigenous air defence shield, will be a game changer, says Rajnath

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday described the indigenous Project Kusha air defence programme as a "game changer" for India's security architecture, asserting that its importance had already been demonstrated during Operation Sindoor.

Addressing scientists and officials in Hyderabad, after inaugurating the Advanced Weapon System Complex of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Defence Research & Development Laboratory (DRDL) in the Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Missile Complex, Mr. Singh said India's indigenous air defence capabilities had successfully thwarted enemy intrusions during the operation.

"Today I predict that Project Kusha will be a game changer for India's security scenario. It is a world-class indigenous air defence system. Just as the Ganadiyan Pill protected the entire region of Bogra, the Brahmos Yoga, and air defence system provided a protective umbrella during that period (Operation Sindoor)," he said.

Project Kusha is a long-range air defence missile system being developed by the DRDO to provide a comprehensive shield against a wide range of aerial threats.

The Defence Minister praised the DRDO's Missile Systems and Strategic Systems cluster for steering India's technological excellence, strategic autonomy and national security. He said indigenous systems such as Akash and Nag have proved India's capability to compete in the global defence technology ecosystem.

Changing warfare

Highlighting the changing nature of warfare, Mr. Singh said emerging technologies such as precision-strike systems, integrated air defence networks, hypersonic weapons, autonomous platforms, artificial intelligence and electronic warfare were reshaping modern battlefields.

Referring to the government's reforms, "Mission Sudarshan Chakra", Mr. Singh said the Initiative would establish a multi-layered missile defence shield capable of protecting military assets, critical infrastructure and civilian establishments across the country.

The Defence Minister lauded the DRDO's progress in indigenous missile technologies, stating that the recent successes in strategic and tactical weapon programmes reflected India's growing self-reliance and confidence in defence manufacturing.

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Compromised PM cannot protect sons of India: Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Friday criticised Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the deaths of three Indian seafarers in U.S. military strikes on commercial vessels off the coast of Oman, alleging that the Prime Minister had remained silent despite the loss of Indian lives.

In a post on X in Hindi, the Congress leader questioned the Prime Minister's response to the incidents.

"Three Indians have been killed in U.S. attacks on three ships in international waters within three days. And our compromised PM... Not a single word. When any foreign power murders an Indian, the Prime Minister has to speak up. But he can never utter even one word," Mr. Gandhi said.

"Next week at the G7, just days after the murder of our sailors, Modiji will smile, embrace, and sign agreements – but for those three Indians, he won't have a word to spare," he said, adding, "A compromised PM cannot protect the sons of Mother India, because he lacks either the courage or the strength to confront those who took the lives of those sons."

The remarks came a day after the Congress condemned "reckless military actions" by the U.S. and demanded that the Union government take all necessary diplomatic measures to establish accountability.

Country is drifting towards electoral autocracy: Cong.

Congress accuses BJP of subverting democratic institutions for political gain in connivance with the poll body, and says the fight is between the 'constitutional model' and the 'Modi model'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday intensified its attack on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Election Commission of India (ECI) over the rejection of its Rajya Sabha candidate Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination from Madhya Pradesh, alleging that the ruling party had graduated from "vote chori" to "seat chori" (seat theft). It said the country was "drifting towards electoral autocracy".

The principal Opposition party said the BJP and the poll body were perpetrating crime, and the ruling party was subverting democratic institutions for political gain. The party's charge came in a press conference attended by 61 Congress MLAs from Madhya Pradesh, who travelled to Delhi to express support for Ms. Natarajan and seek an appointment with the President.

The MLAs, who had planned to march from the party's 24 Akbar Road office to the Rashtrapati Bhavan, were detained by the Delhi Police.

Leaders pointed out that Ms. Natarajan required the backing of only 58 legislators to secure election to the Upper House, fewer than the party's strength in Madhya Pradesh.

Madhya Pradesh Congress president Jitu Patwari alleged that the BJP resorted to extraordinary measures after failing to engineer defections within the Congress Legislature Party.

Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly Umang Singhar said the episode reflected a broader democratic decline. "The country is drifting towards electoral autocracy," he said, citing what he alleged was the centralisation of executive power, weakening of legislative oversight and curbs on freedom of expression.

AICC Madhya Pradesh in-charge Harish Chaudhary said the constant in the country was now between the "constitutional model" and the "Modi model". He alleged that institutions meant to function impartially were increasingly acting in a partisan manner.

Explaining her exile, Ms. Natarajan said other nominations had been rejected on the ground that she failed to disclose a criminal case in Form 26.

She maintained that no criminal case was pending against her and that the matter referred to by the Returning Officer was a private complaint on which no court had taken cognisance.

"The root of this entire matter is Form 26," she said. "If there was a column for it, I would have given the details." She exposed that election rules required disclosure only of cases in which charges had been framed or a court had formally taken cognisance.

"The Congress also alleged "double standards in the scrutiny of nominations, contrasting Ms. Natarajan's case with that of BJP-backed candidate Pyarmal Nakhwani in Jharkhand.

It said that while Mr. Nakhwani faced "critically stringent" scrutiny, Mr. Nakhwani was given opportunities to rectify deficiencies in his papers.

In a separate attack on the BJP, Congress general secretary (Communications) Jairam Ramesh accused Union Home Minister Amit Shah of attempting to "engineer" a two-thirds majority for the ruling party in Parliament by encouraging defections from Opposition parties.

"The lights on. His vehicle again must run and will not succeed," Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X.

Hitting out: Congress leader Pyarmal Nakhwani with MLAs and leaders from Madhya Pradesh addressing the media at Akbar Bhawan in Delhi on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Congress doesn't require 'neutrality of the Indian state' to function: Rahul

Subhani K. Nair
NEW DELHI

"The Congress does not require the 'neutrality of the Indian state' to operate, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said during the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) meeting held on June 5.

The Congress on Friday released the audio and the transcript of Mr. Gandhi's speech made in the closed door meeting of the INDIA bloc. The address, which was out the mud ahead for the Opposition in the 18th Lok Sabha election, positions the Congress as the leader of the bloc while also spelling out the limitations within which the bloc will have to operate.

"The Congress is a party of resistance. It does not require the neutrality of the Indian state to operate. In fact, the more the institutions of the Indian state are throttled, the more aggressively the Congress will fight to defend the Constitution," Mr. Gandhi said. The party seemed to have timed the release of the speech on a day when the Supreme Court rejected the plea against the disqualification of Mahakshi Natarajan, the Congress candidate for the Rajya Sabha elections from Madhya Pradesh.

He flayed the Congress as a "resistance movement", in contrast of the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh "tightening their grip on the Indian state," and rendering conventional political tools increasingly ineffective.

> The Congress is a party of resistance...In fact, the more the institutions of the Indian state are throttled, the more aggressively the Congress will fight to defend the Constitution
>
> RAHUL GANDHI
> Congress leader

'Resistance works'

"If political parties can't function, what functional Resistance functions. Resistance works. Wherever we resist, it works. I have seen it with my own eyes. I have walked 4,000 kilometres across this country – resistance works," he said. Mr. Gandhi also addressed the criticism levelled against his party by allies. "It is not my place to answer any of the things that were said today about the Congress. It is my place to, like in the Shastra tradition, swallow everything. The idea of the blue-necked One (Shiva) who carries all the poison. Whatever more you were to say, we will accept it happily with a smile on our face," he said.

He argued that the Congress occupies a fundamentally different role within the alliance. "I do not say this with arrogance. Our role, as many of you have stated, is to unite all of you together with love and affection," he said, assuring the leadership of the INDIA bloc.

He expressed confidence in key allies, saying: "...I can reach right now for the DMK. When it comes to defending the idea of India, every single person will be in this room."

At the same time, he did not gloss over internal contradictions. "We have our fights, but if you are asking me to go and hug the ex-Chief Minister of Kerala – I cannot and I will not, because I have an ongoing political fight with him," he said.

On electoral prospects

Striking a confident note on electoral prospects, he told allies: "The next elections has already been won. Please understand, there is so much anger among the people of India that the next election is already over. The problem is the capture of the instruments of the nation state by the RSS. The problem is that you will not have a free and fair election to win," he said.

4,000 EVMs gutted in Bengal govt. building fire; Minister flags 'foul play'

Sagnik Sengupta
KOLKATA

Around 4,000 electronic voting machines (EVMs) were gutted after a government building in Kolkata's Alipore area that houses the South 24 Parganas Zila Parishad office and district units of several other departments caught fire on Wednesday, said officials, flagging a possibility of sabotage.

Minister of State for Fire and Emergency Services Sovanik Chowdhury said, "The incident took place on Wednesday afternoon. It's a nine-storey building in Alipore that houses the South 24 Parganas Zila Parishad, local District Postal Officer's (DPO) office, and also the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyaan. The EVMs were stored in a room on the ninth floor. All of those EVMs have been gutted."

According to the Minister, these EVMs have been used in at least 13 constituencies across Kolkata, North 24 Parganas, and South 24 Parganas during the recent Assembly election.

Mr. Chowdhury, who went to visit the site, also flagged a possibility of sabotage. "Prima facie, the fire first broke out at the third and fourth floors. It is not yet clear how it reached the eighth and ninth floors while the fifth, sixth, and seventh floors were safe. It isn't normal. The fire services personnel were also called pretty late. We are investigating the matter. The District Magistrate was also asked to launch a probe. They are trying to trace who entered and set the fire."

An officer from the Alipore police station also said that the Additional District Magistrate has lodged an FIR based on which a four-member special investigation team (SIT) was formed to investigate the matter.

A fire broke out at a government building in Kolkata's Alipore area that houses the South 24 Parganas Zila Parishad office. ANI

New govt. will bring Tatas back to Bengal, says Suvendu Adhikari

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday said the government would bring the Tata Group back to the State. However, he added that the land at Singur on which Tata Motors had set up a car factory is not tied up with the State government as it had been returned to the farmers.

"The farmers at Singur cannot grow any crops because the concrete bonded for the factory got mixed with the soil," the Chief Minister said. The withdrawal of Tata Motors from Singur in 2008 is considered a setback for the industrialisation drive of West Bengal. After a protracted legal battle, the land acquired by the Left Front government at Singur was returned to the farmers of West Bengal by Mamata Banerjee during the Trinamool Congress regime.

Speaking on prospects of an exodus to Tata's proposed car factory in Karnataka's Mudigere, the Adhikari led government is serious on attracting investments to the State.

Mr. Adhikari said that for stable accounting land like the Left Front government or forcing industries out of the State like the Trinamool government was not the solution.

Jairam urges Defence Minister to reconsider expansion of INS Baaz

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Congress Rajya Sabha member Jairam Ramesh, on Friday, wrote to Defence Minister Rajnath Singh urging him to reconsider the rejection of a full runway expansion at INS Baaz on Campbell Bay. He said that the alternative now being pursued – a greenfield airport at Galathea Bay in Great Nicobar – carries far heavier ecological and social costs than the government has acknowledged.

The letter follows the order on Minister's June 8 assertion that India would invest around ₹13,000 crore in a dual-use airport and runway for civilian and naval operations.

Mr. Ramesh's letter responds to media reports attributed to Defence Ministry sources, that runway expansion at INS Baaz would be limited because its 4,500 feet would damage the surrounding environment. He questioned the timing of their concern. "I appreciate the sudden worry for ecological protection," he wrote.

The proposed airport, he wrote, would require clearing around 205 acres of protected forest and the forcible relocation of several hundred families from parts of the Shompen tribal community.

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IN BRIEF

Two held for throwing stones at train with RSS chief aboard

Two persons have been arrested for allegedly throwing stones at the Swarn Shatabdi Express, plying between Lucknow and New Delhi, in which Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat was travelling. The incident occurred around 2.30 a.m. on Thursday when the train was approaching Firozabad station of Prayagraj division. The miscreants were identified from CCTV footage and arrested. Railway CPRO Shashikant Tripathi said. Mr. Bhagwat was travelling in the B1 coach. The stone hit the exterior window near seat 56. "The interior side of the window was not affected," Mr. Tripathi said.

BRICS backs people-centric, inclusive urban development

The BRICS nations on Friday adopted a declaration on inclusive, resilient and people-centred urban development. The Ministerial declaration adopted on the concluding day of the 13th BRICS Urbanisation Forum in the national capital, highlighted key priorities shared by member nations and reaffirms commitment to advancing people-centred urban development. It emphasises the importance of creating inclusive, sustainable, resilient and liveable cities that ensure equitable access to urban services, particularly for marginalised groups, according to an official statement of the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

Families of Air India crash victims demand answers

Family members and the Federation of Indian Pilots bemoaned that there was no statement from the Prime Minister or the Gujarat CM; nor was any public representative present at the gathering

Abhinay Deshpande
AHMEDABAD

There were tears and somber pauses as families of the Air India crash victims gathered at a hotel in Ahmedabad to mark the first anniversary of the disaster on a chilling note for the dead.

While many have received compensation from the airline, they said justice still eluded them and they blamed the government for not release the final report on the crash. "We want answers... We are still waiting to know the cause of the accident," one of the family members said.

"My daughter died a year ago, and we are still waiting for answers. From the government on how it [the crash] has taken place... there is no official statement or clarity on what exactly happened on that ill-fated day," said Amithbai Patel from Sirohi. His daughter, Vibhuti Patel, a physiotherapist in the U.K., was aboard the London-bound Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner which crashed moments after taking off from Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on June 12, 2025. "My daughter came to India for 15 days and was engaged to a man from Gujarat who was living in the U.K.," Mr. Patel said, wiping away tears.

The aircraft went down barely seconds after takeoff, killing 260 people, including 241 passengers and the crew, and 19 people on the ground. Former Gujarat Chief Minister Vijay Rupani was one among those killed.

While tributes were paid to the victims, whose photographs were adorned with garlands, rose petals, and lamps, the family members and the Federation of Indian Pilots bemoaned that there was no statement from the Prime Minister or the Gujarat Chief Minister, nor any public representative was present on the first anniversary of the crash.

"If a similar incident had occurred elsewhere in the world, particularly in Western countries, people would have gathered and the entire Air India staff and the families affected, and I thank my team who stood up immediately to support them and have continued to do so in the toughest circumstances. I am back with some of them in Ahmedabad today," she added.

Kin after a tribute at the crash site on the first anniversary of the tragedy in Ahmedabad. AFP

Mocked absence

British High Commissioner to India Lindy Cameron reached the crash site in the city's Meghaninagar area and offered floral tributes to the victims, saying her thoughts were with all the families affected by the tragedy.

She was among the rare dignitaries to pay her respects at the crash site, and her visit made the absence of State or Union government representatives more conspicuous.

Fifty-two British nationals were among the 260 persons killed in the incident. "One year ago today, the tragic Air India crash claimed 260 lives, including 52 British nationals," Ms. Cameron said in a post on X. "I will never forget arriving in Ahmedabad and visiting the site on that day. My thoughts are with all the families affected, and I thank my team who stood up immediately to support them and have continued to do so in the toughest circumstances. I am back with some of them in Ahmedabad today," she added.

Families of the victims also demanded that a memorial be built at the crash site.

Cabinet Secretary reviews NEET-UG re-test preparations

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

T.V. Somanathan

Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan on Friday reviewed the preparedness for the NEET re-test, in a meeting with the Director-General of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

"The Central government, state governments and district administration are working together in close coordination, to ensure smooth conduct of the NEET re-examination. The full might and weight of the law will fall on any person trying in any manner to distort, disrupt or tamper with the integrity or smooth conduct of the re-examination," Mr. Somanathan said in a statement.

The NEET re-examination is scheduled to be held on June 21.

During the review, the Cabinet Secretary also emphasised the need for ensuring a smooth, transparent, and secure conduct of the re-examination through close coordination among all stakeholders concerned.

Mr. Somanathan had reviewed the arrangements with the Secretaries of the Union government and relevant agencies on June 1. Subsequently, on June 4, he also held a review meeting with the Chief Secretaries of the States to assess the preparedness and progress of the arrangements.

These meetings are aimed at ensuring effective coordination, strengthening preparedness, and maintaining the integrity and credibility of the NEET re-examination process.

The NEET-UG was held on May 3, but was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak.

The CBI is investigating the case and has made several arrests.

The NEET-UG re-examination is scheduled to be held on June 21

'Deep-seated' bias for male child persists in society: SC

Aarathika Ilanumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has observed that although the country's child sex ratio has shown "clear signs of improvement", the continued prevalence of son-selection practices reflects "deep-seated patriarchal preferences" for a male child.

A Bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and P.K. Mishra made the observation while dismissing a Maharashtra doctor's appeal challenging criminal proceedings against him under the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act, 2994 (PCPNDT Act).

Referring to various schemes introduced by State governments to curb female foeticide, the court said these reflected sustained efforts to address the systemic discrimination faced by "the girl child in an inherently patriarchal society.

The court noted that the country continues to face significant gaps in gender parity

However, it pointed out that several States could cope to record sex ratios at birth below the national average. "...the country's sex ratio has shown clear signs of improvement in recent years... Nonetheless, several States still report sex ratios at birth below the national average. This shows the continuing presence of deep-seated patriarchal predispositions towards a male child and the 'behind the curtain' prevalence of sex selection practices," the Bench said.

Accordingly, the top court stressed that strict enforcement of the PCPNDT Act was all the more essential until entrenched social attitudes towards the girl child undergo change.

The Bench also noted the country continues to face significant challenges in achieving gender parity when assessed against global indicators. "On a global level though, unfortunately, the data does not present a positive outlook. The World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2025 records a drop in our ranking in terms of overall gender parity score from the previous year to 131 out of 148, from 129 the previous year", the Bench said.

Accordingly, the Bench refused to quash the criminal proceedings against the doctor, underlining that "letting infractions slide" would defeat the purpose of the PCPNDT Act.

Govt. opens draft telecom rules on TV, radio for feedback

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has published the draft Telecommunications (Television, Radio and Associated Services) Rules, 2026, for public consultation. They have been framed to consolidate the various guidelines issued for television and radio services under the erstwhile Telegraph Act, within the framework of the newly enacted Telecommunications Act, 2023.

The Information and Broadcasting Ministry administers the provisions relating to television, radio, and associated services.

Unified rule-book

In the draft rules, existing terms and conditions of authorisation have been harmonised and rationalised to facilitate continuity, while enabling reforms and provision for a single regulatory framework in place of multiple guidelines. "With this set of rules, the industry will now have a unified and significantly simplified rule book. These rules are designed to simplify the existing regime while promoting ease of doing business in the television and radio broadcasting sector," said the Ministry.

Once notified, the rules will replace various existing guidelines governing broadcasting services.

Digital implementation of the authorisation process, simplified authorisation procedures, renewal of the requirement for signing Grant of Permission Agreement, and provision of registration adjudicating officer as the Cabinet mechanism are the other key features.

HC denies plea to reopen Class 12 re-evaluation portal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Friday declined to direct the reopening of the CBSE's portal for the re-evaluation of class 12 answer sheets on a petition by the Congress's student wing.

A vacation Bench of Justice Saurabh Banerji Krishna and Justice Madhu Jain observed that an individual student was free to take appropriate action if aggrieved and that reopening the portal, which was operational from June 2-5, would delay the entire process of result declaration.

"Sir you, it is one week, but the whole process gets delayed by a month...it is not as easy," the Bench remarked. "I am not giving further directions. Whoever is aggrieved, let the individual approach."

As the National Students' Union of India's (NSUI) counsel urged the court to order reopening of the portal for a few more days, Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the authorities, submitted that the aggrieved students have already exercised their requests and the disputed answer sheets are being considered.

Mr. Mehta said the NSUI's public interest litigation plea was based on "very general assumptions".

The court said that any aggrieved student or any such legal remedy is lawfully

Govt. says it is mulling policy for students in West Asia

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Friday informed the Supreme Court that it was considering a policy to accommodate private students in West Asia whose examination results could not be declared by the CBSE owing to the prevailing conflict in the region.

A Bench of Justices Augustine George Masih and Vipul Pancholi was informed by Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta that a decision was likely to be taken shortly. He accordingly requested the Bench to defer the hearing to June 22.

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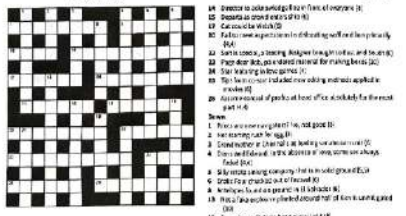

Across

7 Pass various reasons (8)
9 Show character pic one had regretfully called it (8)
10 Dreadful tale I got about (6)
11 Shaggy bird captured by assassin's associate (6)
12 Ship officers' captain arrives over (8)
14 Director to take swinging line in front of everyone (3)
15 Deserts as crew leaves ship (6)
17 Calculate the width (8)
20 Paltry new aspect is seen to defeat ring well and keep physically (6,4)
22 Sartre's essay, a literary Belgian brought out and beaten (6)
23 Page-four list, pre-stored material for making beds (10)
24 Star training in two games (3)
25 This bacteria once included new adding methods applied in modern (8)
26 A concentration of pranks at head office accidentally for the most part (4,4)

Down

1 Prince's answer using plant? Yes, not good (8)
2 Just starting cash by egg (8)
3 Sound mother in Christ's all-in feeding vote about to end (5)
4 Does well forward, in the absence of song, sorrow is always faded (6)
5 Silly article among company that is in social group (5,5)
6 Drink I'm a chemical out of focus (4)
8 Arrangers for a state practice will substitute (8)
13 Pitch a false proposition plotted around half of lion's cunning, quiet (10)
16 Revealing in Orkney but not quite right (8)
18 Churchwoman with no answer? Sacrilegious (8)
19 Devout musician's guitar experiment that's made [accident] in the front (6)
21 Penultimate score a point (6)
22 Person on work's time, being given no necessary by all to save the circle (5)
24 Instrument in a kit for fish? (3)

SUDOKU

	8		5				2	3
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		3			8		9	
4			9	1			5	
		7		4		8		
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DIFFICULTY RATING ★★★★★

Solution for yesterday's Sudoku

4	8	1	3	7	6	5	2	9
5	7	9	1	2	8	6	3	4
6	2	3	4	5	9	8	1	7
3	4	5	6	8	7	1	9	2
1	5	8	9	6	4	3	7	2
7	9	6	2	1	3	4	5	8
8	6	7	5	3	1	2	4	5
9	3	4	8	9	2	7	6	1
2	1	2	7	4	5	9	8	3

FAITH

Conquer the 'I' and 'mine'

Tiruvalluvar says, "He enters the abode of the gods who has the use of 'I' and 'mine.'" One may say that this advice is farcical to follow in the material world that we live in where self-promotion appears to be the norm. Unless one conquers the 'I', one cannot lead a truly enriching life, said Bontal S. Ramakrishnan.

Narayana Ithihasam says Krishna abhors two types of people: those who go about swollen-headed due to their academic achievements (vidvad garvitas) and those who boast about riches (dhanadhya garvitas). Mahabharata ensures that this does not happen with the true devotee.

Rishi's curse calling upon Krishna at the behest of his wife. To Kusela, living in abject poverty, Krishna was a dear friend but his wife pleaded with him to seek material help from the wealthy Krishna. When he agreed to visit Krishna, she sent Kusela with a gift of poha. After offering it to Krishna, Kusela spoke of general affairs and did not seek any help. Taking a fistful of poha and relishing it, the all-knowing Krishna immediately showered wealth upon Kusela, transforming his humble abode into a palatial one. When Krishna reached for the second fistful of poha, Mahalakshmi (having manifested as Rukmini) stopped him. Why did She ? The first fistful of poha was an offering of Krishna bhakti pure, unadulterated friendship and worship. With the second helping of poha, Krishna might shower more gifts upon Kusela, which could make Kusela proud of his affluence. At the onset of such ego, Krishna would distance himself from his dear Kusela. Rukmini (Mahalakshmi) did not want one pitiful for Kusela's devotee and hence She stopped Him from having more poha.

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INBRIEF

Rupee surges 67 paise against 'weaker' U.S. dollar

The rupee surged 67 paise to close at 85.89 against the greenback on Friday as global oil prices fell sharply after U.S. President Donald Trump declared an imminent deal with Iran. A firm trend in domestic equity markets and a weaker American currency also supported the rupee, forex traders said. At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 85.40 and traded in the range of 84.98-85.53 before settling at 85.89, up 67 paise from its previous close. ■

Govt. waives duty on nuclear power equipment imports

In what could serve as a major boost to India's nuclear energy ambitions, the Finance Ministry on its order on Thursday, waived customs duty on specific imports required for capturing generation of nuclear energy. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had announced exempting the basic customs duty exemption on imports necessary for nuclear power projects up to 2035. The latest order takes retrospective effect, extending relief to imports made between April 1, 2025 and January 31 this year.

NLC wins Telangana critical minerals' block bid

NLC India has emerged as the preferred bidder for a Vanadium, Titanium and Aluminous Laterite block in Telangana. "NLC India Limited is identified as preferred bidder for Ruvvadapur Vanadium, Titanium and Aluminous Laterite Block of Sanga Reddy, Telangana, subsequent to the Critical and Strategic mineral blocks auction held on June 11 by the Union Ministry of Mines," the company said in a filing on Friday.

Mandate on solar cell manufacturing may hit projects on books

Approved list of cell manufacturers given effect without ensuring adequate domestic cell manufacturing capacity, says solar association

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Solar energy projects that are on the books and waiting for implementation, may be impacted by the approved list of cell manufacturers (ALCMs) for solar cells that came into effect on June 1.

According to the approved list of module manufacturers (ALMM) order issued in 2019, solar photovoltaic module manufacturers can sell no solar PV cells only from those listed under the ALCM.

The introduction of ALCM may create several challenges for the Indian solar industry as it has come into effect without ensuring adequate domestic cell manufacturing capacity, said C. Somasekhar, president of the Indian Solar Association.

India's module manufacturing capacity has reached approximately 190 GW whereas domestic solar cell manufacturing capacity is only around 25 GW. India's annual solar installation requirement is estimated at about 80 GW. With domestic cell manufacturing capacity substantially lower than demand, a supply deficit is likely to emerge, he told The Hindu.

Data of projects that are awaiting installation in different States are not available publicly. And, the ALCM order for solar PV cells has come into effect just 12 days ago. "However, it has an impact on both prices and performance," said Mr. Somasekhar.

Low voltage: Project implementation of the ALCM has been caught off the cell and solar capacity needs to at least 120 GW. ■

Prior to the implementation of mandatory domestic cell sourcing requirements, solar module manufacturers were able to procure solar cells from international markets through the Basic Customs Duty at 0 to 20%.

It is learnt that imported solar cells are reportedly available at approximately 15 US per watt. The price of domestically manufactured solar cells is said to be in the range of 18 US per watt, he said.

The resulting high costs would ultimately have to be absorbed by project developers, investors, electricity consumers, distribution companies, commercial and industrial consumers, or the government through various support schemes, he said.

With the mandatory Domestic Content Requirement (DCR), many B2C and manufacturing companies may face closure as module availability will become an issue, he added.

Residential rooftop solar installations are going on with DCR cells because consumers get subsidy under PM Surya Ghar.

Commercial installations or solar park development projects constitute 70% of the total installation and will be affected, Mr. Somasekhar said.

Further, limited cell availability may lead to underutilisation of module manufacturing facilities.

"While there are cases in courts regarding this issue, the government should look at a phased implementation of the ALCM till the cell production capacity comes to at least 100 GW," he added.

Govt. bars bulk buyers from retail purchase of petrol, diesel

Sagnik Ganguli Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Seeking to curb the recent "extraordinary" increase in sales of petrol and diesel, the government, in an order late on Thursday, barred industrial and commercial consumers from purchasing petrol and diesel from retail outlets and directed them to source the fuels only from dedicated supply channels.

Additionally, the government also directed retail outlets not to dispense more than 2,000 litres of diesel in a day to either a consumer or a vehicle. The same cannot be resold, according to the order.

The directive would be in force for 90 days unless revoked before the stipulated date.

In a statement on Friday, the government underlined that the latest directive sought to arrest an "unprecedented and extraordinary demand growth" in some retail outlets that is stemming from consumers of bulk diesel increasingly turning to the somewhat-cheaper retail diesel. "This is driven by industrial and direct or institutional and commercial consumers, who have been shifting their procurement from their dedicated customer pumps to retail outlets due to the difference between bulk and retail diesel prices," the statement read.

Procurement of large quantities of diesel injury cans had come to the government's notice.

Bulk diesel is about ₹10 per litre more expensive than the one sold at retail outlets.

Further, according to the government, there has been about 58% decline in sale of diesel among private oil marketing companies in May this year – from the same period last year – owing to comparatively higher prices in their pumps.

Privately-owned oil marketing companies immediately pass on the elevated pressure onto the final consumer of retail fuels sold at their pumps unlike State-owned companies.

State-owned companies' retail pumps in 80 districts have witnessed more than 30% growth in sale of diesel during the same period, the government added.

"Blatant instances of procurement of large quantities of diesel in jerry cans, and its resale have come to the notice of the government," it said.

Investors upbeat as oil becomes cheaper on hopes of peace deal

Ashoka Mithran T.
MUMBAI

Investors were elated after oil prices plummeted 2.8% to $88.1/barrel on hopes of a peace deal between Iran and the U.S. Benchmarks Nifty and Sensex rose over 2% to 23,622.90 and 76,870.90 points on Friday.

Nifty opened at 23,412.55 points, 1.22% above the previous day's close, and traded at about 23,350 before the day's close. Sensex, too, saw a similar pattern.

All sectoral indices improved, with some gaining up to 3% or more. Most stocks that traded in the session advanced, suggesting a broad-based rally.

"The sharp market recovery suggests that investors are beginning to price in a more favourable geopolitical outcome. While a formal agreement remains pending, the moderation in crude oil prices and rupee gain have improved the near-term outlook for domestic equities," said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

NCLT rejects insolvency plea against Noida Metro

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The NCLT has dismissed an insolvency petition filed by Engineer Transport Services Ltd (ETSL) against Noida Metro Rail Corporation observing that there were "genuine" pre-existing disputes between the parties over service quality, commercial obligations and payment deductions.

The Allahabad Bench of NCLT rejected ETSL's plea seeking initiation of Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) against Noida Metro Rail Corporation (NMRC) under Section 9 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

CIRP approached NCLT claiming operational dues of about ₹7.09 crore arising from a bus operations pact signed with NMRC.

Estonia, industry eye trade, defence ties with India

Arsen Deep
TALLINN

Estonian government officials and business executives are expressing greater interest in cooperating with India in defence and trade, even as the Baltic country, with a population of 1.4 lakh, works to strengthen its position amid the Russia-Ukraine war.

"India is one of the most interesting markets because the population is still growing for a long time," Ahti Kamunge, Secretary-General of Estonia's Ministry of Economic Affairs and Communications said in a briefing last month to visiting journalists.

"We definitely have to be more present there." Mr. Kamunge listed areas such as wood chemistry, machinery, drones, and then a little piece of chips

A bee sits on a dandelion flower in a park on a sunny day in Tallinn, Estonia. ■

Union for India's firms.

E-residency

Mr. Tsahkna endorsed Estonia's e-residency programme as a way for prospective entrepreneurs to access global markets.

Medical cooperation

Priit Sõlmsen, founder of Bamby Medtec, which builds AI solutions for fertilisation, said he travelled to the Al Impact Summit in Delhi in February with the Estonian President's delegation.

Saying he had held discussions with incorporating Estonia's technology in Indian hospitals, he said a key policy adjustment applied to U.S. and U.K. would help firms like his.

(The author was in Tallinn at the invitation of the Estonian Ministry of Foreign Affairs)

Global liquor firms chase Telangana for $400 mn dues

Reuters
NEW DELHI

Indian giants representing alcohol giants Diageo, Pernod Ricard, Heineken and Carlsberg, accused Telangana of breaching recruiting rules over dues it owes them totalling about $400 million, India's biggest beer-consuming state by volume. Her many other global governments in India, requires liquor firms to supply only to State-run depots, which then sell to retailers, leaving the firms to rely on State government for payment.

The system has long soured relations with big drinks companies and last year, Telangana officials acknowledged they owed money to liquor firms without giving reasons for the delayed payments.

SpaceX opens 11% higher on Nasdaq

Reuters

SpaceX rose 11% in its Nasdaq debut on Friday, lifting its valuation to about $1.96 trillion as investors piled into the world's largest IPO and bought into Elon Musk's sprawling empire spanning rockets, satellite communications and AI to Wall Street.

A billboard of SpaceX stands at the Times Square, U.S.

The stock opened for trading at $810 compared with the IPO price of $526 per share. The deal was being closely scrutinised because of the stakes for the IPO market, which some bankers said could face difficulties if SpaceX shares close below Thursday's pricing level.

With SpaceX widely viewed as a cross-rehearsal for a new generation of mega-listings, market participants will also be watching for signals on investor appetite ahead of forthcoming IPOs for AI heavyweights Anthropic and OpenAI.

The landmark listing cemented Mr. Musk's status as the first trillionaire ever, cosmic-rocketed SpaceX into the ranks of the world's most valuable companies – even though the firm posted a loss of nearly $5 billion last year and generated only a fraction of the revenue brought in by primarily ethical tech giants.

Nestle India says no infestation in its noodles

Reuters

Nestle India on Friday rejected allegations that insects were found in its Maggi noodles product, after a news agency reported on India's food regulator had risen cognizance of social media complaints and issued notice to the consumer goods company.

Nestle India said in a statement that the concern was raised from an unverified social media account and that the account holder did not respond to repeated requests for the sample.

Testing of a reference sample from the same batch in an independent laboratory notified by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) found no infestation, Nestle India said.

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South Korea's Yoon gets 30 years in jail over North drone incursion

LONDON

David Hockney, iconic British artist known for landscapes, dies at 88

ISLAMABAD

Pakistan hikes defence spending by 17.6% to PKRs 3,000 billion

BANGKOK

Thai Princess Bajrakitiyabha, who was known for her legal work, dies

A deal 'has never been closer', says Iran, after Trump claimed progress

Trump dismisses the leaked draft as 'fake news', saying the reported terms do not match the written deal; JD Vance says economic benefits would flow to Iran if it meets obligations; Tehran says a potential understanding is close to completion

Vinath Johny

A day after U.S. President Donald Trump backed away from a threatened attack on Iran, claiming progress in talks, Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Friday that Washington and Tehran have "never been closer" to reaching a preliminary agreement.

"The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding has never been closer. Pending its finalisation, the media should refrain from erecting speculation about its contents. In line with our responsible and measured approach, all details will be shared with the public in due course," Mr. Araghchi wrote in a social media post. Mr. Trump reposted Mr. Araghchi's statement in his Truth Social account.

Mr. Araghchi's comments came after Iran's *Mehr* news agency, citing a source close to the negotiating team, claimed that the deal would see "the release of $24 billion of Iranian funds blocked during the 60-day final negotiation period". According to a draft of the agreement released by *Mehr*, there would be a permanent halt to fighting on all fronts, "including Lebanon".

It also calls for lifting the U.S. blockade of Iranian ports and reopening the Strait of Hormuz within 30 days. Sanctions on Iranian oil and petrochemical revenues would be suspended, and nuclear negotiations would be held during a 30-day period to reach a final agreement.

Teetering deal: People walk next to a symbolic smoking plane near an oasis, on a road in Tehran, Iran, Thursday. REUTERS

'Great settlement'

Mr. Trump, who on Thursday told pressperson in Oval Office that "a great settlement" with Iran was reached, "subject to finalisation of documents", on Friday dismissed the reports about the content of the deal as "fake news".

"The terms that Iran leaked out to the Fake News have NOTHING to do with the terms that were agreed to, in writing. What they said, including their weak statement on having a deal, bears no relation to the truth," he wrote. It is the first media post Mr. Trump has made on the Iran deal since he announced Easter Sunday as the deadline for Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Vice President J.D. Vance also slammed the spread of "fake information" about the terms of the proposed deal. "Fair, the leaders are not receiving any cash, and no funds are being released for simply signing a deal or attending a meeting," he wrote in a social post.

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said that the U.S. and Iran have agreed to wording of an agreement aimed at ending their war, and that mediators were working with both sides to finalise a deal.

Death toll from protest clashes in PoK rises to 20

Agence France-Presse
MUZAFFARABAD

The death toll from clashes between police and members of a banned protest movement in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir has risen to 20, according to a tally on Friday based on official figures.

Supporters of the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), an anti-government movement demanding economic and governance reforms, have been pressing ahead with protests despite the group being banned under anti-terrorism laws last week.

Officials initially said on Monday that seven persons had been killed — three civilians and four police officers — and dozens wounded.

A new count on Friday saw the number of deaths rise sharply to 20.

The local government's Higher Education Minister, Malik Zafar, said that clashes between protesters and police had left seven persons dead this week in his constituency of Kotli.

Commissioner Sardar Waheed, the top civilian official in the city of Rawalakot, said that 13 people had been killed, including the four police officers.

Khurram Iqbal, a senior police official in the city of Mirpur, said a protester had died during clashes with police on Wednesday.

The Joint Awami Action Committee says it is demonstrating for legitimate economic and political rights. AFP

Many shops in the main city of Muzaffarabad have closed in a show of support for the JAAC's calls for businesses to strike, and mobile internet has been largely inaccessible for residents, amounting to a suppression in the area.

Members of the JAAC have formed their leaders as a terror group as "oppressors", saying they are demonstrating for legitimate economic and political rights.

Philippines protests Chinese sanctions against defence chief

Associated Press
MANILA

Ghana Teodoro Jr.

The Philippine government said on Friday that China's imposition of sanctions, including an entry ban, against Defence Secretary Gilberto Teodoro Jr. was "an unfriendly act" that could further strain relations, while he vowed to continue defending Manila's interests against Beijing's aggression.

The Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Beijing announced late Thursday that Mr. Teodoro and his family have been banned from entering China, including Hong Kong and Macao, over what it described as "irresponsible remarks" he has made that undermined Beijing's interests.

Mr. Teodoro, who was appointed defence chief in June 2025, has been one of the most vocal critics of China's actions in the disputed South China Sea.

Ukraine, Russia trade overnight drone strikes, say officials

Reuters
MOSCOW

Ukraine and Russia exchanged overnight drone strikes into early Friday, with Ukraine targeting a major oil processing and petrochemical region while Russia attacked railway stations and electrical substations.

Ukraine's strikes hit an apartment block in Russia's coastal Tuapse killing three, and Sunak's attack in Ukraine's Sumy region killed a railway worker, officials said.

The strikes follow large air attacks by Russia on Ukraine in recent weeks, while Kyiv has intensified long-range drone strikes on Russian oil facilities, leading to shortages of fuel in Crimea and elsewhere.

Industrial facilities in Tuapse were targeted, regional head Rustem Mikhailuson said on the Telegram messaging app. Regional city Nizhnekamsk will cancel public events on Friday amid the threat of drone attacks, its mayor, Radmir Bulyaev, also said.

The country marks Russia Day on June 12 with a national holiday.

Russia downed 28 Ukrainian drones, news agencies reported, citing Russia's Defence Ministry. Both Russia and Ukraine deny targeting civilians.

U.S. plans to slash fighter jets, warships it provides to NATO in Europe: report

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States plans to slash the number of fighter jets and warships it provides to NATO in Europe, the *New York Times* reported on Thursday.

The report cut back a cause as European nations rush to bolster their defence capacities since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 sparked fears that Moscow could attack a NATO country.

U.S. President Donald Trump has called the alliance a "paper tiger" and its members "cowards" in frustration that they have not joined the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran.

Washington plans to reduce the number of fighter jets it supplies to Europe by one third, cut all aerial refuelling tankers and reduce maritime reconnaissance aircraft, the *New York Times* reported, citing two unidentified senior European officials.

U.S. Air Force Boeing KC-135 Stratotanker refueling aircraft parked at Sofia's West Levski Airport in Bulgaria. AFP

Other assets to be reallocated include a missile-launching submarine, an aircraft carrier, a group of bombers aircraft and several Arleigh Burke warships.

The U.S. European Command said this month that it would reassess Washington's contributions to NATO to "ensure Europe takes primary responsibility for its own conventional defence".

The 32-member North Atlantic Treaty Organisation was founded in 1949 and its collective security is based on the principle that if one member is attacked, the entire alliance comes to its defence.

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